

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Customer Success English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

03 Support Escalations and Incident Communication

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 QBRs and Business Outcomes

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Renewals and Churn Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

06 Expansion and Upsell Ethics

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

07 Product Feedback and Feature Requests

Clarify missing information before responding.

08 Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: onboarding, go-live, implementation, customer owner.

Model response

What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Next Friday is an expectation, not a confirmed go-live - The lesson's customer expects go-live next Friday, while migration responsibilities and training dates remain unassigned.

2. Imported data or validated data? - Separate fictional case: a customer's onboarding tracker says data ready after an upload; the customer has not reviewed the imported records.

3. Administrator training or training for everyone? - Separate fictional case: a fictional onboarding plan lists one training session, but the customer expects both administrator and end-user instruction; audience scope is unconfirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A sandbox mistaken for the live environment

A fictional customer has received access to a sandbox with synthetic records and assumes it is the production environment. Production setup and launch timing are unconfirmed. Hold an onboarding clarification call.

Role A: You are the implementation manager. Clarify which environment was supplied and its intended use.

Role B: You are the customer project owner. Ask what remains before live use and avoid making a launch announcement.

Possible opening: The access provided is for a sandbox with synthetic records, not a confirmed production launch.

Success checks

- Distinguish practice access from production readiness.
- Clarify the customer owner's next questions without inventing completion dates.
- Agree the confirmation needed before live-use instructions are sent.

Add a complication: The customer wants to invite all users to start live work immediately.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

An account has many logins but little use of the workflow it purchased the product to improve.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: adoption, health score, stakeholder engagement, usage.

Model response

Logins show activity, but they do not tell us whether the intended workflow is being adopted. Let's review the relevant usage and ask the customer about the outcome they are trying to achieve.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Many logins, little workflow adoption - The lesson's account has frequent logins but limited use of the workflow the product was purchased to improve.
2. One power user does not represent the whole team - Separate fictional case: one user completes ninety of a team's hundred workflow runs; no information about the other users' readiness has been reviewed.

3. A green score based on stale engagement data - Separate fictional case: a customer health score remains green using an old sponsor-meeting record; the sponsor has since changed and current engagement is unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Automated activity in a usage count

A fictional account dashboard counts 1,000 events, including an unknown number from scheduled automation. Human use of the purchased workflow has not been separated. Explain why the total cannot directly establish user adoption.

Role A: You are the success analyst. Distinguish recorded events from human workflow participation.

Role B: You are the account manager. Ask how to identify the relevant usage before interpreting the health score.

Possible opening: The event total includes automation, so it doesn't yet tell us how many people are using the workflow.

Success checks

- Distinguish events, users, and adoption.
- Keep the automation share explicitly unknown.
- Agree a data-definition check before drawing a health conclusion.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call all events active users.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Support Escalations and Incident Communication

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A customer issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date. A draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: escalation, severity, workaround, SLA.

Model response

We have a verified workaround, but the permanent-fix date is not confirmed. I'll explain the workaround and state the next update time without promising an unverified resolution date.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. B - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. A verified workaround, not tomorrow's permanent fix - The lesson's issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date; a draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

2. A fix deployed but not yet verified with the customer - Separate fictional case: engineering deployed a candidate fix for a report-export issue; customer-environment verification has not finished.

3. The workaround covers exports, not scheduled delivery - Separate fictional case: a verified workaround allows manual report export; scheduled email delivery remains affected and no permanent-fix date is confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A reported workaround failure in a second configuration

A fictional workaround was verified in configuration A. The customer reports it did not work in configuration B, and that second report has not been reproduced. Give a scoped escalation update.

Role A: You are the support lead. Separate the verified A result from the reported B failure.

Role B: You are the customer success manager. Ask for the next authorized verification and what can be communicated now.

Possible opening: The workaround is verified in configuration A; the reported failure in B still needs investigation.

Success checks

- State the tested configuration and limit the claim accordingly.
- Keep the second report visible without calling its cause confirmed.
- Agree the next verification and customer communication step.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to say the workaround is universally reliable based on the first test.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

QBRs and Business Outcomes

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A business review claims a large return on investment using estimated time savings that the customer has not validated.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: QBR, business outcome, ROI, executive sponsor.

Model response

The return estimate depends on unverified time-saving assumptions. Let's review those assumptions with the customer and label the result as an estimate rather than a demonstrated outcome.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Estimated savings do not establish validated ROI - The lesson's business review claims substantial return on investment from estimated time savings the customer has not validated.

2. A pilot outcome outside the full account scope - Separate fictional case: a pilot team reduced measured report preparation from four hours to three; no other teams have been measured.

3. Time released is not automatically payroll saved - Separate fictional case: a customer validates reduced time on a reporting task but has not measured any reduction in payroll or other expenditure.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The baseline came from a different team

A fictional business review compares the current team's two-hour task with another team's old five-hour estimate. The tasks and measurement methods have not been matched. Discuss whether the comparison supports a customer saving claim.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Identify the unmatched baseline and avoid claiming a three-hour achieved saving.

Role B: You are the customer's analytics lead. Ask for comparable task definitions and measurement evidence.

Possible opening: The five-hour baseline came from another team, so it doesn't yet establish what this team saved.

Success checks

- State the baseline mismatch explicitly.
- Distinguish a numerical difference from a validated improvement.
- Agree a like-for-like measurement before making an outcome claim.

Add a complication: An executive wants the larger saving kept because it looks impressive.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Renewals and Churn Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

An account renews in six weeks. The main contact has changed, and the team has not confirmed current priorities.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: renewal, churn risk, commercial term, value gap.

Model response

Could we arrange a review with the current decision makers to confirm priorities and unresolved issues? That will help us understand the renewal discussion before assuming the previous plan still fits.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Six weeks to renewal, new priorities unknown - The lesson's renewal is six weeks away; the main contact has changed and current customer priorities are unconfirmed.
2. A renewal conversation needs the service owner - Separate fictional case: a procurement contact requests renewal pricing but has no information about whether the service team still uses the purchased workflow.

3. A competitor inquiry is a clarification opportunity - Separate fictional case: a customer mentions reviewing another supplier, but has not stated an intention to cancel or explained the comparison criteria.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A renewal reminder sent to the departed contact

A fictional renewal reminder went to a former employee. The commercial review is still pending, and the new responsible contact has not been identified. Request the appropriate owner and a realistic response arrangement.

Role A: You are the renewal coordinator. Explain the contact gap and request an authorized replacement contact.

Role B: You are the customer's operations administrator. Confirm that the former employee has left and identify whom you must ask about ownership.

Possible opening: Our reminder reached the former contact; could you help identify who now coordinates the renewal review?

Success checks

- Distinguish an outdated contact from a cancellation decision.
- Request the correct owner and purpose-specific meeting.
- Agree a follow-up without inventing approval authority or renewal intent.

Add a complication: A colleague treats the lack of reply as proof that the customer intends to cancel.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Expansion and Upsell Ethics

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A customer is considering more licenses while many existing users have not completed onboarding.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: upsell, expansion, use case, readiness.

Model response

Additional licenses may be useful, but adoption of the current ones is still incomplete. Let's compare expansion with improving onboarding against the customer's immediate goals before recommending the next purchase.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. More licenses or better use of existing capacity? - The lesson's customer considers more licenses while many current users have not completed onboarding.
2. A new department pilot or an account-wide add-on - Separate fictional case: a customer asks about an add-on for five departments, but only one department has described a concrete use case; requirements elsewhere are unknown.

3. An advanced feature versus a simpler workflow change - Separate fictional case: a customer seeks faster approval handling; a paid advanced module is available, but a change to its existing workflow might help and neither option has been tested.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Seasonal demand or permanent license expansion

A fictional customer expects a short busy period but has not confirmed how many additional users need access or for how long. Existing license flexibility is unreviewed. Compare permanent expansion with checking current arrangements first.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Ask for duration and user requirements and explain the comparison criteria.

Role B: You are the customer team lead. Describe the uncertainty and seek a proportionate option without assuming temporary terms exist.

Possible opening: Before discussing permanent expansion, let's confirm the additional users, duration, and flexibility in your current arrangement.

Success checks

- Keep user count and duration explicitly unconfirmed.
- Compare scope and readiness without inventing available contract options.
- Agree a requirements and terms check before recommending expansion.

Add a complication: A salesperson presents permanent licenses as the only option without checking the current terms.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Product Feedback and Feature Requests

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A customer asks for a specific feature, but the product team needs to understand the underlying workflow and current obstacle.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: feature request, roadmap, workaround, product feedback.

Model response

What task are you trying to complete, and what prevents you from doing it today? I'll record the workflow and impact so the product team can evaluate the request without treating a proposed feature as the only solution.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. The requested feature is not yet the requirement - Separate fictional case aligned with the lesson: a reporting coordinator requests red warning badges because they open each invoice row to check approval before a Friday export. Individual approvals must remain, and supported display alternatives have not been checked.
2. A bulk button request with an approval constraint - Separate fictional case: a customer requests bulk approval, but says each item currently requires a separate review; the intended boundary of the proposed shortcut is

unclear.

3. An export request with an unknown recipient need - Separate fictional case: a customer asks for a new export format because an external reviewer cannot use the current file; the reviewer's required structure is unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A mobile request that may concern notifications

A fictional customer asks for a mobile app but explains only that field staff miss updates while away from desks. Their devices, access constraints, and notification needs are unknown. Clarify the need before discussing roadmap options.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Ask what staff need to notice or do away from their desks.

Role B: You are the customer's field operations lead. Explain what is known and identify which user details you must gather.

Possible opening: When you request a mobile app, which update or action do field staff need while away from their desks?

Success checks

- Separate the proposed app from the underlying workflow need.
- Request device and access context without guessing it.
- Keep roadmap inclusion and timing explicitly uncommitted.

Add a complication: The customer asks for a launch date before the workflow is clarified.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A frustrated customer says a feature was promised for this month. The record contains an estimate, not a confirmed commitment.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: boundary, executive escalation, commitment, expectation setting.

Model response

I understand why you expected it this month. The earlier wording did not clearly distinguish an estimate from a commitment. I'll clarify the current status and discuss the available options with the responsible team.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. An estimate was heard as a commitment - The lesson's frustrated customer believes a feature was promised this month; the record contains an estimate rather than a confirmed commitment.
2. An informal chat sounded like round-the-clock support - Separate fictional case: an account manager's casual message said contact me anytime; the customer interpreted it as a new round-the-clock response commitment,

which is not recorded.

3. A review commitment mistaken for a feature commitment - Separate fictional case: a success manager promised to take a request to product; the customer now says that meant product had agreed to build it.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A request for unlimited custom help

A fictional customer interpreted an offer to help with setup as unlimited custom configuration work. No expanded service scope was agreed. The customer has three requested changes, but their effort and support coverage have not been reviewed. Repair expectations and set a respectful boundary.

Role A: You are the customer success manager. Acknowledge the broad wording and offer a scoped review of the requests.

Role B: You are the customer administrator. Explain the expectation and ask what can genuinely be assessed next.

Possible opening: Our offer to help with setup was too broad; we need to clarify which work is covered before making further commitments.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the unclear expectation without blaming the customer.
- Keep unreviewed effort and coverage explicitly open.
- Agree a scoped review rather than an unlimited service promise.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to promise all three changes immediately as an apology.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Customer Success English

Professional audience: customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Original fictional case: A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: onboarding: The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively. / go-live: The point at which a system or service begins its intended operational use. / implementation: Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation. / customer owner: The person on the customer's side responsible for coordinating an agreed activity.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Customer Success English

Professional audience: customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Original fictional case: A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: onboarding: The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively. / go-live: The point at which a system or service begins its intended operational use. / implementation: Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation. / customer owner: The person on the customer's side responsible for coordinating an agreed activity.

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Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level